



Morning rain 55/31 • Tomorrow: Mostly sunny 43/31 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, FEBRUARY 13, 2025 • \$4

At least it’s spring somewhere



SAUL MARTINEZ FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Pitchers and catchers had their first official workout Wednesday at the Nationals’ spring training complex in West Palm Beach, Florida. After back-to-back 71-win seasons, the Nationals are optimistic they will improve this year — a sentiment shared by 29 other teams at spring training. Opening Day is March 27. **Story, D1**

White House shuts buyout window after legal win

BY OLIVIA GEORGE, STEVE THOMPSON AND EMILY DAVIES

A judge on Wednesday lifted his pause on the federal government’s deferred resignation program, prompting the Trump administration to swiftly declare victory as it closed the offer to any more workers who might still have been mulling it.

The program — which encouraged federal workers to resign with the promise of pay through September — had been halted since last Thursday, when U.S. District Judge George A. O’Toole Jr. temporarily stopped the Office of Personnel Management from moving ahead. Unions represent-

Move comes shortly after judge lifts pause on bid to pare federal workforce

ing more than 800,000 federal workers had filed a lawsuit to stop the program, calling it an “arbitrary, unlawful, short-fused ultimatum.”

In his ruling, O’Toole wrote that the unions’ lawsuit could not succeed because they lacked standing to sue and because his court lacked jurisdiction. The unions, the judge said, were not directly impacted by the administration directive “but are chal-

lenging a policy that affects others, specifically executive branch employees.”

“This is not sufficient,” he wrote, for the unions to sue under the Administrative Procedure Act. O’Toole, who was nominated in 1995 by President Bill Clinton, did not opine on the buyout program’s legality.

The ruling left a serious question: How much time would federal employees who had not yet signed up have to throw their names in? None, it turned out. McLaurine Pinover, spokesperson for the Office of Personnel Management, said the program was closed as of 7 p.m. “There is no longer any doubt,” she said in a statement. “The Deferred Resig-

nation Program was both legal and a valuable option for federal employees.”

About 75,000 workers have accepted the deal, Pinover said.

The decision out of the Massachusetts courthouse — and the Trump administration’s move immediately afterward — mark another milestone in a tumultuous period for federal workers, who

SEE BUYOUTS ON A9

Deputy AG: Ex-Trump lawyer won’t pledge recusal if confirmed. **A2**

A boon for Big Tech: Trump issues industry-friendly directives. **A15**

Media: The White House barred two AP reporters from events. **C1**

Israeli strike on Iran likely, says U.S. intelligence

ATTACK ON NUCLEAR SITES WITHIN MONTHS

A test for Trump, who speaks of peace but backs ally

BY JOHN HUDSON, MICHAEL BIRNBAUM AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

Israel is likely to attempt a strike on Iran’s nuclear program in the coming months in a preemptive attack that would set back Tehran’s program by weeks or perhaps months but escalate tensions across the Middle East and renew the prospect of a wider regional conflagration, according to U.S. intelligence.

The warnings about a potential Israeli strike are included in multiple intelligence reports spanning the end of the Biden administration and the beginning of the Trump administration, none more comprehensive

than an early January report produced by the intelligence directorate of the Joint Chiefs of Staff and the Defense Intelligence Agency.

The report warned that Israel is likely to attempt a strike on Iran’s Fordow and Natanz nuclear facilities in the first six months of 2025. Current and former U.S. officials familiar with the intelligence told The Washington Post that the finding derives from an analysis of Israel’s planning following its bombing of Iran in late October, which degraded its air defenses and left Tehran exposed to a follow-on assault. The officials spoke on the condition of anonymity to discuss

SEE IRAN ON A9

Trump, talking to Putin, launches bid to end war

Remarks after call about Ukraine represent major concessions to Russia

BY MICHAEL BIRNBAUM, MATT VISER AND ROBYN DIXON

President Donald Trump spoke by phone on Wednesday to Russian President Vladimir Putin in their first publicized call since Trump returned to the White House, breaking a years-long silence between the Oval Office and the Kremlin as the U.S. leader kicked off a bid to end Russia’s war in Ukraine.

Trump had warm words for the Russian leader — who has ruled Russia for 25 years and has repeatedly invaded neighboring nations and killed, imprisoned or exiled

his most formidable opposition — as he declared that the two men would visit each other’s countries and “agreed to work together, very closely.”

Trump, who also spoke with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky later in the day, said he and Putin would probably meet without Zelensky in Saudi Arabia “in the not-too-distant future.”

“I think President Putin wants peace, and President Zelensky wants peace. And I want peace,” he told reporters in the Oval Office. “I just want to see people stop getting killed. We’re very far away from that particular war, but that’s a vicious war.”

The call, which the Kremlin said lasted nearly 90 minutes, illustrated the deepening alliance between Trump and Putin in ways

SEE PUTIN ON A12

NATO: With Trump team’s arrival, Europe braces over spending. **A12**

Firings begin as Musk team works to trim civilian ranks

This article is by Emily Davies, Jeff Stein, Hannah Natanson, Lisa Rein and Tony Romm

Billionaire Elon Musk’s team has initiated sweeping layoffs of federal employees, as the Trump administration races to shrink the government’s civilian workforce.

An official with the Office of Personnel Management, which is now run by Musk allies, emailed staff Wednesday morning stating that widespread layoffs — known as “reductions in force” — have begun and are already overwhelming the small agency that functions as a human resources department for the government, according to a copy of the message obtained by The Washington Post. OPM has also begun to assert more control over all federal hiring, according to four employees of the agency and additional internal communications also obtained by The Post.

SEE LAYOFFS ON A16

Among drill instructors, a rising pattern of suicide

Marine Corps job was always stressful, but changes have made it unbearable for some, observers say



ZACH MEYER FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

BY KELSEY BAKER AND DREW F. LAWRENCE

BEAUFORT, S.C. — Tatiana Sowell held her youngest child as she stood amid the rows of white headstones and stately mossy oaks. Her husband, Logan, was buried in this national cemetery nearly four years ago after taking his life and ending what his widow describes as a ruinous tenure in one of the U.S. military’s most iconic jobs: Marine drill instructor. He was 33.

Nearby, her other children spotted a coin, regarded within the armed forces as a symbol of respect, resting atop his grave. Perhaps, she thought, it was left there by someone who worked with him molding new Marines at Parris Island, just south of here.

Sowell, her gaze wistful, reflected on the times she had driven Logan to work. “It was just quiet,” she recalled. “Peaceful.”

Logan Sowell’s suicide in July 2021 is one of at least seven in the past five years involving the Marine Corps’ stable of drill instructors, according to military casu-

SEE DRILL INSTRUCTORS ON A6

President is installed as Kennedy Center chair

BY TRAVIS M. ANDREWS, MANUEL ROIG-FRANZIA, JANAY KINGSBERRY AND MATT VISER

The Kennedy Center board of trustees voted Wednesday afternoon to install President Donald Trump as chairman of the board, cementing the plan Trump announced Friday to overhaul the storied arts institution with him at its helm. It also voted to terminate Deborah Rutter as president and made former acting director of national intelligence Richard Grenell interim president, according to multiple people with knowledge of the meeting who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to speak publicly.

Trump attended the virtual board meeting. The refashioned board of trustees is made up entirely of Trump appointees, many of whom were appointed after he terminated all of former presi-

SEE KENNEDY CENTER ON A9

IN THE NEWS

Gabbard confirmed The former Democratic congresswoman was sworn in as director of national intelligence after losing only one Republican vote in the Senate. **A4**

Glock is sued Officials in Maryland seek steps to prevent the company’s guns from being modified into machine-gun-like weapons. **B1**

THE NATION
Education nominee Linda McMahon’s record often clashes with Trump’s agenda. **A3**
Trump’s undermining of checks and balances carries extraordinary risks, experts argued. **A8**

THE WORLD
Over 100 Russian civilians fled to Ukraine from the Kursk region after a blast there. **A11**
Fears about fresh fighting swept over Gaza as a ceasefire appeared to be on shaky ground. **A13**

THE ECONOMY
The president wants to end the production of pennies, but it would still take years for the coins to disappear. **A14**
Warning labels about toxic chemicals are seemingly everywhere in California, and a new study finds that they have been effective. **A15**

THE REGION
Maryland voters view some proposed cuts to the state’s Blueprint law as unacceptable, a poll has found. **B1**
Seven men, including two teachers, were arrested in a Fairfax County sting operation targeting child sex abuse. **B1**

STYLE
Beautiful creatures were in abundance in New York, where the dog show and Fashion Week overlapped. **C1**

LOCAL LIVING
For the friend mom of a friend group, it can be a journey from lone trail-blazer to revered oracle of parental wisdom.

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